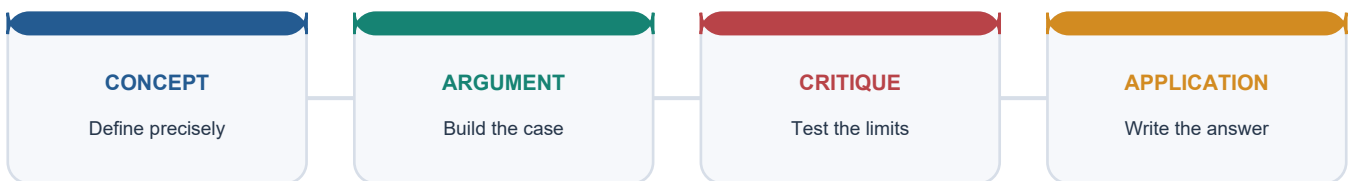


SOLVED PRACTICE WORKBOOK

Neolithic and Chalcolithic Cultures: Solved Practice Workbook

Ancient History • Topic 05 • Solved Practice

LEARNING PATH



Deterministic fallback visual: move from precise concepts through argument and critique to exam application.

Source order: repository knowledge -> official current linkage -> clearly marked analysis. No fabricated PYQs or statistics.

Workbook Contents

Major learning parts and meaningful subtopics are listed in document order. Page numbers are generated from the final PDF layout; PDF bookmarks mirror the same hierarchy.

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Neolithic and Chalcolithic Cultures: Solved Practice Workbook

Source discipline: the 32 MCQs and six Mains questions are original. The 2021 Prelims question is transcribed from the local official paper; its answer is clearly labelled inferred because the matching official key is unavailable locally.

BASIC MCQS / REMEDIATION

32 ORIGINAL HARD MCQS

Correct options rotate strictly A -> B -> C -> D, repeated eight times. All 128 option explanations and all 32 examiner traps are question-specific.

Q1

Which combination is the strongest diagnostic basis for calling a context Neolithic?

- A. Food-production evidence read with settlement and an associated tool-craft assemblage
- B. A single polished celt found on the surface
- C. Any handmade pot regardless of context
- D. The first appearance of a copper ornament

Answer: A.

Option-wise explanation:

- **A:** Correct: This bundle connects subsistence, residence and technology in context.
- **B:** Incorrect: A surface celt lacks the associations needed to diagnose economy.
- **C:** Incorrect: Pottery can occur without farming and needs secure context.
- **D:** Incorrect: Copper is compatible with several later or overlapping settings.

Examiner trap 1: Do not let one visually distinctive artefact substitute for an assemblage.

Q2

Which sequence best preserves the evidentiary distinction in archaeobotany?

- A. Domestication -> presence -> cultivation -> dependence
- B. Presence -> possible use -> cultivation -> domestication -> economic dependence
- C. Cultivation -> presence -> migration -> ethnicity
- D. Pottery -> grain -> state taxation -> urbanism

Answer: B.

Option-wise explanation:

- **A:** Incorrect: The order reverses the inferential steps and assumes the conclusion.
- **B:** Correct: This sequence separates increasingly demanding claims.
- **C:** Incorrect: Neither migration nor ethnicity follows from crop remains.
- **D:** Incorrect: Ceramics and grain do not establish taxation or cities.

Examiner trap 2: A plant at a site is not automatically a domesticated staple.

Q3

Which evidence most strongly supports managed herding rather than occasional hunting?

- A. One cattle tooth without context

- B. A species name in an old excavation report
- C. A patterned age-sex kill profile with pens, dung and secure chronology
- D. A figurine interpreted as a bull

Answer: C.

Option-wise explanation:

- **A:** Incorrect: An isolated tooth cannot establish population management.
- **B:** Incorrect: A label without methods or assemblage data is too weak.
- **C:** Correct: Converging demographic and contextual evidence directly tests herd control.
- **D:** Incorrect: Representation does not demonstrate economic management.

Examiner trap 3: Domestication is an assemblage-level population process.

Q4

Why is pottery not a universal marker of the beginning of farming?

- A. Because all early farmers used metal vessels
- B. Because pottery appears only in cities
- C. Because pottery cannot store grain
- D. Because food production may precede pottery and pottery can occur among foragers

Answer: D.

Option-wise explanation:

- **A:** Incorrect: Perishable containers and aceramic farming contradict this claim.
- **B:** Incorrect: Ceramics occur in many non-urban contexts.
- **C:** Incorrect: Storage and cooking are major ceramic functions.
- **D:** Correct: The histories of pottery and farming can intersect without coinciding.

Examiner trap 4: Associated innovations need not begin together.

Q5

What is the safest inference from substantial storage facilities in a village?

- A. Delayed consumption and organised access to reserves became important
- B. A centralized tax state certainly existed
- C. All households possessed equal surplus
- D. The settlement had abandoned mobility completely

Answer: A.

Option-wise explanation:

- **A:** Correct: Storage directly extends the time horizon of consumption and risk management.
- **B:** Incorrect: Taxation needs institutional evidence beyond bins or jars.
- **C:** Incorrect: Capacity and access can be unequal across households.
- **D:** Incorrect: Seasonal mobility can coexist with stored village reserves.

Examiner trap 5: Storage supports planning; it does not automatically prove the state.

Q6

Which geographical statement about Mehrgarh is correct?

- A. It is in the Kashmir Valley of present-day India
- B. It lies in the Kachi plain of Baluchistan in present-day Pakistan

- C. It is a middle-Ganga rice site in Bihar
- D. It is a southern ash-mound settlement in Karnataka

Answer: B.

Option-wise explanation:

- **A:** Incorrect: Burzahom and Gufkral, not Mehrgarh, anchor the Kashmir sequence.
- **B:** Correct: This locates the site accurately within the wider north-western subcontinent.
- **C:** Incorrect: Middle-Ganga and eastern sequences are separate regional pathways.
- **D:** Incorrect: Southern cattle-ash-mound sites belong to another ecological zone.

Examiner trap 6: Historical subcontinental relevance must not erase present-day geography.

Q7

Which pair is correctly matched?

- A. Burzahom - rock-cut shrine complex
- B. Gufkral - Mature Harappan dockyard
- C. Burzahom - pit structures and strong bone-stone tool evidence
- D. Mehrgarh - eastern Indian post-built settlement

Answer: C.

Option-wise explanation:

- **A:** Incorrect: Burzahom is not known for rock-cut shrines.
- **B:** Incorrect: Gufkral belongs to the Kashmir Neolithic, not Harappan maritime urbanism.
- **C:** Correct: This is the diagnostic Kashmir association.
- **D:** Incorrect: Mehrgarh is a north-western site with mud-brick architecture.

Examiner trap 7: Pit structures are not rock-cut temples.

Q8

What is the best use of the Burzahom human-animal burial evidence?

- A. It proves one named religion
- B. It establishes a universal dog cult
- C. It demonstrates hereditary kingship
- D. It supports mortuary and human-animal relationship questions while leaving belief uncertain

Answer: D.

Option-wise explanation:

- **A:** Incorrect: No text or repeated symbolic system identifies a named creed.
- **B:** Incorrect: One burial pattern cannot establish a universal cult.
- **C:** Incorrect: Mortuary association is not institutional proof of monarchy.
- **D:** Correct: This interpretation preserves the evidence and its limits.

Examiner trap 8: Burial treatment is observable; theology is reconstructed cautiously.

Q9

Which statement about Koldihwa-Mahagara is most defensible?

- A. They are central to rice debates, but dates and wild/domestic identification require caution
- B. They conclusively prove the world's first domesticated rice
- C. They are copper-mining settlements in Rajasthan

- D. They contain no continuity from Mesolithic technology

Answer: A.

Option-wise explanation:

- **A:** Correct: This states both historical importance and the core evidentiary qualification.
- **B:** Incorrect: The chronology and rice taxonomy do not support such certainty.
- **C:** Incorrect: Ganeshwar-Jodhpura, not these sites, anchors the Khetri copper context.
- **D:** Incorrect: Microlithic and heavier stone traditions can continue into the sequence.

Examiner trap 9: Earliest claims must survive context, date and taxonomy checks.

Q10

Why is Lahuradewa significant?

- A. It proves that all rice farming diffused from Mehrgarh
- B. It strengthens an early middle-Ganga rice-cultivation pathway
- C. It is the type-site of Jorwe pottery
- D. It is a Kashmir pit-dwelling site

Answer: B.

Option-wise explanation:

- **A:** Incorrect: Its significance is precisely that a one-way model is insufficient.
- **B:** Correct: This is the bounded regional inference supported by the site.
- **C:** Incorrect: Jorwe belongs mainly to the western Deccan.
- **D:** Incorrect: Burzahom and Gufkral represent the Kashmir sequence.

Examiner trap 10: A regional centre does not by itself prove one independent domestication event.

Q11

Which description best fits Chirand?

- A. A Khetri-belt copper workshop
- B. A south Indian ash mound only
- C. A Bihar site with a long Neolithic-Chalcolithic sequence, bone tools and mixed riverine subsistence
- D. A Mature Harappan port

Answer: C.

Option-wise explanation:

- **A:** Incorrect: Ganeshwar-Jodhpura is the relevant copper-craft complex.
- **B:** Incorrect: Chirand belongs to eastern riverine archaeology, not the ash-mound zone.
- **C:** Correct: This integrates location, sequence, tools and subsistence.
- **D:** Incorrect: Harappan maritime urbanism is a different context.

Examiner trap 11: Site identification should combine region, period and diagnostic evidence.

Q12

How should similarities between Daojali Hading tools and eastern Asian forms be used?

- A. As proof of one race
- B. As proof of a known language
- C. As a precise date without samples
- D. As a contact or comparison hypothesis requiring independent chronological evidence

Answer: D.

Option-wise explanation:

- **A:** Incorrect: Artefact form cannot identify biological population.
- **B:** Incorrect: Language does not follow from a stone-tool resemblance.
- **C:** Incorrect: Typological similarity is not an absolute date.
- **D:** Correct: This preserves the comparative value without overclaiming migration.

Examiner trap 12: Similarity generates a testable question, not an ethnic conclusion.

Q13

Which statement best characterises the South Indian Neolithic?

- A. Cattle pastoralism, cultivation, ground stone, pottery and varied mobility could coexist
- B. It was uniformly urban and literate
- C. It lacked all crop production
- D. Every site was a temporary cowpen

Answer: A.

Option-wise explanation:

- **A:** Correct: This captures the mixed pastoral-agricultural settlement spectrum.
- **B:** Incorrect: Urban institutions and writing are not diagnostic of these contexts.
- **C:** Incorrect: Cultivation is documented within regional sequences.
- **D:** Incorrect: Habitation sites and more persistent settlements accompanied some camps.

Examiner trap 13: Cattle prominence must not erase agriculture or settlement diversity.

Q14

Which interpretation of ash mounds is most defensible?

- A. They were all volcanic deposits
- B. They reflect repeated burning of cattle-linked accumulations, with function assessed site by site
- C. They were all royal crematoria
- D. They prove a single pan-Indian ritual

Answer: B.

Option-wise explanation:

- **A:** Incorrect: Archaeological dung and activity evidence contradicts a volcanic origin.
- **B:** Correct: This fits formation evidence while allowing practical and symbolic variation.
- **C:** Incorrect: No royal institution is established by the deposits.
- **D:** Incorrect: Regional formation histories defeat a universal ritual claim.

Examiner trap 14: Do not force one function onto every ash mound.

Q15

Which relation between pastoralism and agriculture is best supported?

- A. They are mutually exclusive stages
- B. Pastoralism necessarily disappears with storage
- C. They can interact through manure, fodder, traction, mobility and risk-spreading
- D. Cultivation proves permanent immobility

Answer: C.

Option-wise explanation:

- **A:** Incorrect: Mixed economies repeatedly contradict the staged binary.
- **B:** Incorrect: Stored grain and mobile herding can form one seasonal system.
- **C:** Correct: These mechanisms explain their complementarity.
- **D:** Incorrect: Food production does not eliminate seasonal movement.

Examiner trap 15: Treat livelihood strategies as a portfolio, not a binary.

Q16

What does 'Chalcolithic' most precisely indicate?

- A. An iron-using urban civilization
- B. A society using only copper tools
- C. A single ethnic culture across India
- D. Copper or copper-alloy objects coexisting with stone and other technologies

Answer: D.

Option-wise explanation:

- **A:** Incorrect: Iron is not the defining metal of the term.
- **B:** Incorrect: Stone remained economically important.
- **C:** Incorrect: Regional culture labels do not name one people.
- **D:** Correct: This is the correct technological meaning.

Examiner trap 16: Copper presence does not mean total metal replacement.

Q17

Which association is correct for Ahar-Banas?

- A. South-eastern Rajasthan, black-and-red ware, copper and farming-herding settlements
- B. Kashmir, pit dwellings and bone harpoons
- C. Assam, shouldered celts and uncertain dates
- D. Western Deccan, Jorwe ware and Inamgaon

Answer: A.

Option-wise explanation:

- **A:** Correct: This combines the region and diagnostic assemblage.
- **B:** Incorrect: Those features belong to the Kashmir Neolithic.
- **C:** Incorrect: Those are north-eastern reference traits.
- **D:** Incorrect: That pairing identifies the Jorwe sphere.

Examiner trap 17: Keep Ahar-Banas distinct from both Harappan cities and other Chalcolithic cultures.

Q18

Why is Ganeshwar-Jodhpura important?

- A. It was the capital of a Harappan empire
- B. It links a copper-craft concentration to the Khetri resource zone and wider contacts
- C. It proves OCP and copper hoards were one people
- D. It is the earliest rice site in the Ganga plain

Answer: B.

Option-wise explanation:

- **A:** Incorrect: Contact evidence does not establish imperial status.
- **B:** Correct: This is the bounded resource-craft-exchange interpretation.
- **C:** Incorrect: Partial association cannot be converted into ethnicity.
- **D:** Incorrect: Its diagnostic importance is copper, not rice domestication.

Examiner trap 18: Ore proximity and exchanged forms do not prove political absorption.

Q19

Which inference from rich Kayatha deposits is strongest?

- A. They prove an egalitarian village
- B. They prove a hereditary monarchy
- C. They suggest unequal access or affluent households while the institution of rank remains uncertain
- D. They prove every copper object was locally mined

Answer: C.

Option-wise explanation:

- **A:** Incorrect: Concentrated valuables are inconsistent with a simple equality claim.
- **B:** Incorrect: Material concentration alone cannot establish monarchy.
- **C:** Correct: This distinguishes observable inequality from a named political system.
- **D:** Incorrect: Provenance must be established before assigning ore source.

Examiner trap 19: Inequality is easier to infer than the exact institution producing it.

Q20

Which sequence is most appropriate for central-western Chalcolithic comparison?

- A. Harappan -> Mesolithic -> Kayatha
- B. Jorwe -> Lower Palaeolithic -> Malwa
- C. Daojali Hading -> Savalda -> Burzahom
- D. Kayatha and Malwa horizons compared with Savalda and later Deccan sequences site by site

Answer: D.

Option-wise explanation:

- **A:** Incorrect: The phases and regions are incorrectly ordered and combined.
- **B:** Incorrect: A Palaeolithic phase cannot be inserted as a Chalcolithic successor.
- **C:** Incorrect: These sites belong to unrelated north-eastern, Deccan and Kashmir contexts.
- **D:** Correct: This comparison preserves distinct horizons and local chronology.

Examiner trap 20: Do not turn relative cultural sequences into one mechanical all-India ladder.

Q21

Which feature is associated with Malwa culture?

- A. Painted pottery and substantial villages at sites such as Navdatoli and Eran
- B. Pit dwellings at Burzahom
- C. Shouldered celts at Daojali Hading alone
- D. Rock-cut shrines at Ganeshwar

Answer: A.

Option-wise explanation:

- **A:** Correct: This is a representative Malwa association.

- **B:** Incorrect: Pit structures identify the Kashmir sequence.
- **C:** Incorrect: The north-eastern assemblage does not define Malwa.
- **D:** Incorrect: Ganeshwar is a copper-craft complex, not a shrine site.

Examiner trap 21: Use culture-site-marker triads rather than isolated site names.

Q22

What is the safest statement about Savalda?

- A. It is identical to Mature Harappan urbanism
- B. It is an early western-Deccan Chalcolithic horizon in the Tapi region, distinguished by its own ceramic sequence
- C. It is a Kashmir aceramic phase
- D. It is a north-eastern Neolithic migration marker

Answer: B.

Option-wise explanation:

- **A:** Incorrect: Its rural regional context differs from Harappan urbanism.
- **B:** Correct: This captures its region, relative position and diagnostic ceramic role.
- **C:** Incorrect: Kashmir has a different sequence and material pattern.
- **D:** Incorrect: No north-eastern migration claim follows from Savalda.

Examiner trap 22: Savalda is a distinct horizon, not a spare label for Jorwe.

Q23

Which statement best describes Jorwe culture?

- A. It is restricted to one copper mine
- B. It is defined by iron technology
- C. It is a western-Deccan Chalcolithic tradition with painted pottery and varied settlement hierarchy
- D. Every Jorwe settlement was an urban centre

Answer: C.

Option-wise explanation:

- **A:** Incorrect: The culture spans a regional settlement network.
- **B:** Incorrect: Copper-stone, not iron, frames its Chalcolithic setting.
- **C:** Correct: This combines its location, pottery and settlement diversity.
- **D:** Incorrect: Hamlets, villages and larger centres must be distinguished.

Examiner trap 23: A wide distribution does not imply one polity or one settlement type.

Q24

What does Inamgaon most securely demonstrate?

- A. A deciphered script and palace bureaucracy
- B. A universal chiefdom model for India
- C. A direct Harappan colony
- D. A detailed rural Chalcolithic sequence with houses, storage, craft, burials and changing subsistence

Answer: D.

Option-wise explanation:

- **A:** Incorrect: Neither writing nor palace administration is established.
- **B:** Incorrect: Chiefdom remains an interpretive model, not a universal fact.

- **C:** Incorrect: Interaction does not make it a Harappan colony.
- **D:** Correct: This is the defensible micro-case use.

Examiner trap 24: Use Inamgaon deeply but never generalise it to every Jorwe site.

Q25

Which statement best fits eastern Chalcolithic evidence?

- A. Rice, fish, animals, regional pottery and post-built houses can form a mixed village assemblage
- B. Copper abundance alone defines social complexity
- C. All eastern sites copied Ahar pottery
- D. Sparse architecture proves absence of organisation

Answer: A.

Option-wise explanation:

- **A:** Correct: This reflects riverine mixed economies and regional material traditions.
- **B:** Incorrect: Complexity cannot be ranked by one metal count.
- **C:** Incorrect: Eastern ceramics and sequences have their own histories.
- **D:** Incorrect: Preservation and excavation affect architectural visibility.

Examiner trap 25: Material scarcity in excavation is not automatic social simplicity.

Q26

How should differential grave goods be interpreted?

- A. As proof of a named afterlife doctrine
- B. As evidence of unequal treatment or possible status, tested against age, context and wider patterns
- C. As proof that every village had kings
- D. As evidence that burials were economically irrelevant

Answer: B.

Option-wise explanation:

- **A:** Incorrect: Objects alone do not disclose a precise theology.
- **B:** Correct: This moves from observable difference to a bounded social inference.
- **C:** Incorrect: Political office requires stronger and repeated institutional indicators.
- **D:** Incorrect: Mortuary expenditure can be socially and economically significant.

Examiner trap 26: Mortuary difference permits graded inference, not certainty about belief or rank.

Q27

Which comparison between Harappan and non-Harappan Chalcolithic communities is sound?

- A. Both were identical because both used copper
- B. Every rural culture was a failed city
- C. They could overlap and exchange while differing in urban scale, writing, planning and institutional integration
- D. Harappan decline ended all farming villages

Answer: C.

Option-wise explanation:

- **A:** Incorrect: Shared material does not erase differences in scale and organisation.
- **B:** Incorrect: Teleological ranking misunderstands regional adaptation.
- **C:** Correct: This preserves interaction and diagnostic distinctions.

- **D:** Incorrect: Rural and regional continuities persisted unevenly.

Examiner trap 27: Overlap does not mean identity; difference does not mean isolation.

Q28

What is required before drought is used to explain settlement abandonment?

- A. A dry climate anywhere in India
- B. One abandoned house
- C. A later literary memory
- D. Chronological alignment, a plausible mechanism and comparison with social-economic alternatives

Answer: D.

Option-wise explanation:

- **A:** Incorrect: Remote climate evidence cannot explain a local event by itself.
- **B:** Incorrect: One structure cannot establish settlement-wide causation.
- **C:** Incorrect: Much later texts do not substitute for contemporary proxies.
- **D:** Correct: This is the correct multi-causal test.

Examiner trap 28: Environmental correlation must be converted into a dated mechanism.

Q29

Which statement best describes transition toward Iron Age and Early Historic formations?

- A. Iron, copper-stone and older village practices overlapped unevenly across regions
- B. Iron instantly eliminated copper and stone everywhere
- C. Every Chalcolithic village became an Early Historic city
- D. The transition proves one migrating population

Answer: A.

Option-wise explanation:

- **A:** Correct: This preserves regional continuity and asynchronous change.
- **B:** Incorrect: Technologies and lifeways did not disappear on one date.
- **C:** Incorrect: Settlement trajectories varied and many villages remained rural.
- **D:** Incorrect: Material transition cannot identify one people.

Examiner trap 29: Later technology does not create a universal replacement boundary.

Q30

What is an 'archaeological culture'?

- A. A biologically homogeneous race
- B. A recurring association of material traits used analytically in a region and period
- C. A proven language community
- D. A state with known borders

Answer: B.

Option-wise explanation:

- **A:** Incorrect: Material similarity does not establish biology.
- **B:** Correct: This is the controlled analytical meaning.
- **C:** Incorrect: Language needs independent evidence.
- **D:** Incorrect: Political territory cannot be inferred from pottery distribution alone.

Examiner trap 30: Culture labels classify patterns; they do not name ready-made peoples.

Q31

Which site-region-feature set is correctly matched?

- A. Daojali Hading - Maharashtra - Jorwe ware
- B. Inamgaon - Kashmir - pit dwelling sequence
- C. Piklihal - southern Deccan - cattle-linked habitation and ash-mound landscape
- D. Gilund - Assam - shouldered celts

Answer: C.

Option-wise explanation:

- **A:** Incorrect: Daojali Hading is in Assam and belongs to a north-eastern context.
- **B:** Incorrect: Inamgaon is a western-Deccan Chalcolithic site.
- **C:** Correct: This is the defensible southern association.
- **D:** Incorrect: Gilund belongs to the Ahar-Banas complex in Rajasthan.

Examiner trap 31: Site questions are solved through the full region-period-marker triad.

Q32

Which inference about social organisation is least defensible?

- A. Public works can imply coordinated labour
- B. Craft concentrations can suggest specialisation
- C. Unequal storage can suggest differentiated access
- D. A large house automatically proves a hereditary chiefdom

Answer: D.

Option-wise explanation:

- **A:** Incorrect: Coordination is a reasonable but still bounded inference.
- **B:** Incorrect: Repeated production debris can support specialised activity.
- **C:** Incorrect: Access patterns can reveal household inequality.
- **D:** Correct: House size alone cannot identify hereditary political office.

Examiner trap 32: Chiefdom is a model requiring converging settlement, production and mortuary evidence.

PYQS AND ANSWER PRACTICE

VERIFIED ROUTED PYQ ONLY

2021 PRELIMS GS-I, QUESTION 37

Official-paper wording:

Consider the following pairs:

Historical place	Well-known for
1. Burzahom	Rock-cut shrines
2. Chandraketugarh	Terracotta art
3. Ganeshwar	Copper artefacts

Which of the pairs given above is/are correctly matched?

- (a) 1 only

- (b) 1 and 2
- (c) 3 only
- (d) 2 and 3

INFERRED ANSWER - NOT OFFICIALLY VERIFIED: (d) 2 and 3, high confidence. The local official paper is verified; a matching official 2021 key is not held locally.

- Burzahom is a Kashmir Neolithic site known for pit structures, stone/bone tools and burials, not rock-cut shrines.
- Chandraketurgarh is well known for terracotta art; it is cross-period evidence included because the official question combines periods.
- Ganeshwar-Jodhpura is associated with copper artefacts near the Khetri resource zone.

Why this earns marks: each pair is tested independently through place -> period -> diagnostic feature, while key status remains honest.

SIX ORIGINAL MAINS QUESTIONS WITH MODEL SOLUTIONS

ORIGINAL MAINS 1 - 10 MARKS

Question: Explain why the transition to food production in ancient India should be described as a regional mosaic rather than a single Neolithic Revolution.

Word limit: 150 words.

Food production transformed subsistence, but it did not arrive as one package or on one date. Mehrgarh supplies a long north-western sequence of cereals, managed animals, mud-brick settlement and later pottery. In the Belan and middle-Ganga zones, Koldihwa-Mahagara and Lahuradewa make rice and cattle central, yet dating and wild/domestic identification remain contested. Burzahom-Gufkral adapted village life to Kashmir, while southern sites such as Piklihal and Utnur foreground cattle, mobility and ash mounds. Older microliths, hunting, fishing and gathering persisted beside cultivation and herding. Therefore the transition was major in consequence-storage, durable settlement and new labour schedules-but asynchronous, reversible and regionally mediated in process.

Independent model-answer count: 106 words.

Demand decoding: Answer the directive directly; organise each body paragraph as claim -> named evidence -> analysis -> qualification.

Compression plan: Definition/thesis + three regional evidence units + one caution + verdict.

Why this earns marks: it addresses every clause, uses named archaeological evidence, explains what that evidence proves, and states a source or causal limit.

ORIGINAL MAINS 2 - 10 MARKS

Question: What can and cannot be inferred from the South Indian Neolithic ash mounds?

Word limit: 150 words.

Ash mounds securely indicate repeated cattle-linked activity and burning within South Indian Neolithic landscapes. Utnur connected an ash mound with a post-hole enclosure interpreted as a cattle pen, while Piklihal combines habitation and cattle-herding evidence. These contexts support claims about dung accumulation, herd management, periodic aggregation and the importance of pastoralism within mixed economies. They do not prove that every mound was produced identically or served one ritual. Burning may have combined sanitation, renewal, feasting, communal gathering and symbolic action. Nor does an ash mound alone establish permanent settlement or social rank. The sound conclusion is site-specific: formation process, associated habitation, chronology and botanical-faunal evidence must control interpretation.

Independent model-answer count: 108 words.

Demand decoding: Answer the directive directly; organise each body paragraph as claim -> named evidence -> analysis -> qualification.

Compression plan: Definition/thesis + three regional evidence units + one caution + verdict.

Why this earns marks: it addresses every clause, uses named archaeological evidence, explains what that evidence proves, and states a source or causal limit.

ORIGINAL MAINS 3 - 15 MARKS

Question: Analyse how domestication, storage and settlement changed economic and social organisation without producing a uniform evolutionary outcome.

Word limit: 250 words.

Domestication changed relations among people, plants, animals and time. At Mehrgarh, cereals, managed herds and mud-brick compartments show repeated production and investment; however, pottery and craft intensified across phases rather than appearing together. Mahagara's cattle evidence and the rice debates at Koldihwa-Lahuradewa show another pathway in which Mesolithic tools and wild resources persisted. Southern cattle-centred sites combined seasonal movement, cultivation and ash-mound activity, proving that food production did not require complete immobility.

Storage shifted consumption from immediate acquisition to annual planning. Bins, pits and jars protected reserves but also enabled unequal household access, inheritance claims and coordinated labour. Durable houses and public works could support craft and exchange. At Inamgaon, variation in houses, storage, production and burials permits an inference of rural differentiation.

Yet the evidence does not establish a universal progression to class, chiefdom or city. Preservation is selective, household roles are not directly visible, and mobility could increase during stress. Domestication therefore expanded demographic and organisational possibilities while regional ecology and institutions produced divergent outcomes.

Independent model-answer count: 167 words.

Demand decoding: Answer the directive directly; organise each body paragraph as claim -> named evidence -> analysis -> qualification.

Compression plan: Definition/thesis + four to six evidence-led dimensions + counter-limit + graded verdict.

Why this earns marks: it addresses every clause, uses named archaeological evidence, explains what that evidence proves, and states a source or causal limit.

ORIGINAL MAINS 4 - 15 MARKS

Question: Discuss the major non-Harappan Chalcolithic cultures as regional agrarian-craft societies.

Word limit: 250 words.

Chalcolithic denotes copper-stone coexistence within wider farming, herding, ceramic and village assemblages; it does not mean universal metal use or urbanism. Ahar-Banas settlements such as Ahar, Gilund and Balathal combined black-and-red ware, copper and mixed agriculture in south-eastern Rajasthan. Ganeshwar-Jodhpura, near the Khetri resource zone, specialised in copper objects and interacted with the Harappan world without becoming simply a Harappan political unit.

In western Madhya Pradesh, Kayatha and Malwa horizons are distinguished by ceramics, settlement and craft; Navdatoli and Eran illustrate substantial villages without Harappan-scale urban institutions. Savalda marks an early western-Deccan horizon, while Jorwe sites across Maharashtra developed painted pottery, farming, craft and settlement hierarchy. Inamgaon gives detailed evidence for houses, storage, burials and changing subsistence. Eastern complexes such as Pandu Rajar Dhibi and Chirand used rice, fish, livestock and regional pottery.

These societies were connected through metals, stone, shell and beads, yet retained regional ecologies and chronologies. They should be analysed as plural rural networks, not failed Harappan cities or names of homogeneous peoples.

Independent model-answer count: 166 words.

Demand decoding: Answer the directive directly; organise each body paragraph as claim -> named evidence -> analysis -> qualification.

Compression plan: Definition/thesis + four to six evidence-led dimensions + counter-limit + graded verdict.

Why this earns marks: it addresses every clause, uses named archaeological evidence, explains what that evidence proves, and states a source or causal limit.

ORIGINAL MAINS 5 - 20 MARKS

Question: Critically examine the proposition that archaeological culture labels are analytical tools, not equations for peoples.

Word limit: 250 words.

Archaeological culture labels group recurring material associations in a defined time and region. 'Ahar-Banas', 'Malwa' or 'Jorwe' therefore helps compare pottery, houses, tools, crops, burials and settlement patterns. The labels reveal real historical regularities: Ahar-Banas linked copper and black-and-red ware in south-eastern Rajasthan; Malwa pottery marked central Indian village networks; Jorwe were accompanied varied western-Deccan settlements.

The equation culture = people nevertheless fails. Objects travel through exchange, potters imitate styles, and one community can use multiple traditions. Ganeshwar copper forms and Harappan contacts do not prove political absorption. OCP settlements and copper hoards overlap only partly and cannot identify 'Aryans' or another ethnic population. Likewise, shouldered celts at Daojali Hading make eastern comparisons possible but do not prove migration or language.

The method must proceed from context to inference: establish stratigraphy and date; define the assemblage and distribution; test production and exchange; compare settlement, subsistence and biological evidence; then state alternatives. Even repeated material boundaries may express markets, marriage networks, ecological adaptation or political frontiers.

Thus culture labels are indispensable classificatory hypotheses. They become misleading only when converted into biologically, linguistically or politically uniform peoples without independent evidence.

Independent model-answer count: 187 words.

Demand decoding: Answer the directive directly; organise each body paragraph as claim -> named evidence -> analysis -> qualification.

Compression plan: Definition/thesis + four to six evidence-led dimensions + counter-limit + graded verdict.

Why this earns marks: it addresses every clause, uses named archaeological evidence, explains what that evidence proves, and states a source or causal limit.

ORIGINAL MAINS 6 - 20 MARKS

Question: Evaluate continuity and change from Neolithic and Chalcolithic communities toward Iron Age and Early Historic formations.

Word limit: 250 words.

The transition was uneven rather than a replacement of stone by copper, copper by iron and village by city. Neolithic communities already combined polished stone, microliths, pottery, cultivation, herding and storage in regionally different ways. Chalcolithic societies added limited copper, diagnostic ceramics, craft networks and larger settlement hierarchies while stone and wild-resource use continued.

Harappan urbanism overlapped with many rural communities but differed in city scale, planning, writing, standardisation and integrated exchange. Contacts with Ahar-Banas or Ganeshwar-Jodhpura show interaction, not a common political system. After Harappan urban contraction, regional Chalcolithic traditions did not simply descend from cities; Jorwe, Malwa and eastern sequences followed distinct trajectories.

Iron use spread during the first millennium BCE at different rates and did not immediately eliminate copper, stone or older agrarian practices. Some settlements contracted or shifted; at Inamgaon, aridity has been proposed for later change, but mobility, crop-herd choices and exchange reorganisation must also be tested. Early Historic states and towns therefore emerged from selective regional continuities, new technologies and institutions rather than one automatic stage sequence.

The archaeological record supports transformation through overlap: innovations accumulated, but their social meaning depended on ecology, labour, exchange and political organisation.

Independent model-answer count: 194 words.

Demand decoding: Answer the directive directly; organise each body paragraph as claim -> named evidence -> analysis -> qualification.

Compression plan: Definition/thesis + four to six evidence-led dimensions + counter-limit + graded verdict.

Why this earns marks: it addresses every clause, uses named archaeological evidence, explains what that evidence proves, and states a source or causal limit.